

Monday, 15 May 2023

Meeting Communiqué

Commonwealth, state, and territory Agriculture Ministers met virtually on Monday 15 May 2023.

Commonwealth Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt welcomed new members the Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Western Australian Minister for Agriculture and Food and the Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, New South Wales Minister for Agriculture and returning members.

Ministers discussed biosecurity, including federal Budget outcomes, the Red Imported Fire Ants Eradication Program, the National Traceability Strategy, animal welfare, sustainable agriculture programs and progress on agricultural workforce matters.

Animal Welfare – standards and guidelines

Ministers agreed that both the agriculture sector and the general community have a strong interest in the humane treatment of animals.

Ministers discussed work in progress by agriculture senior officials to improve the process for developing nationally consistent animal welfare arrangements, to ensure clarity, harmonisation and timeliness.

The Queensland Minister for Agriculture and Fisheries, the Hon Mark Furner MP, outlined progress in the work Queensland is leading to update standards and guidelines for livestock at processing facilities and establishments, which is expected to be completed in 2024.

Biosecurity

Federal Budget

Minister Watt updated ministers on the outcomes of the federal Budget, including the \$1 billion investment in a sustainable funding model for biosecurity. Ministers welcomed the new funding model as a key measure to reduce biosecurity risk at our national borders.

National Red Imported Fire Ants Eradication Program (NRIFAEP)

Minister Furner updated ministers on work led by Queensland to eradicate Red Imported Fire Ants. While eradication efforts have already avoided large costs across the country, increasing detections highlight the challenge of fully eliminating the species, which has become a major problem in other countries and has been estimated to cost the economy \$5.3 billion if allowed to establish nationally.

The work will be progressed over the next 12 months and will be discussed at the next AMM in July.

National Agricultural Traceability Strategy 2023–2033

Ministers endorsed the National Agricultural Traceability Strategy 2023–2033. This first ever National Agriculture Traceability Strategy will drive a coordinated national approach to enhancing traceability and enhance the value and reputation of our food and fibre products domestically and internationally. The strategy was developed with direct input from industry, academia, research institutions and other stakeholders and covers all stages of production from farm or boat, through processing, distribution, and retail.

Ministers also noted the progress being made on implementation of traceability reforms for sheep and goats with the sheep and goat traceability taskforce having now released an implementation plan.

Horse Traceability

Ministers noted an update on implementation of horse traceability reforms. Actions include the establishment of a National Horse Traceability Implementation Taskforce to oversee the implementation of a national horse traceability system. Victoria will coordinate the Secretariat for the Taskforce.

Sustainable agriculture update

Ministers agreed that continuing to work with the agriculture sector on increased sustainability and adaptation to climate change is crucial for the sector's future.

Minister Watt discussed the importance of collaboration to realise the opportunities and benefits for farmers, rural communities and the environment through sustainability and initiatives in progress. The Commonwealth is working closely with the states and territories on development of the National Statement on Climate Change and Agriculture and the Drought Resilience Funding Plan which guides all Future Drought Fund investments.

Minister Watt updated ministers on initiatives in the Federal Budget to invest \$302 million in climate-smart, sustainable agriculture programs over the next five years under the next phase of the Natural Heritage Trust.

Ministers discussed key state and territory sustainable agriculture initiatives, noted increasing consumer and market expectations to meet ESG principles, along with strong interest in the sector in the potential benefits to farm profitability from taking measures to improve sustainability.

Agriculture workforce

Minister Watt provided an update on the tripartite (industry-union-government) Agricultural Workforce Working Group. Ministers welcomed the working group's recent, ground-breaking agreement on key principles to underpin a national labour hire licensing scheme.

This is first time that agriculture and processing sector employer groups and unions have reached such an agreement. The working group has submitted the principles to the Commonwealth Minister for

Employment and Workplace Relations, the Hon Tony Burke MP for consideration in designing the national labour hire licensing scheme. Delivery of the scheme fulfils a recommendation of the Migrant Workers' Taskforce.

Minister Watt also highlighted other areas of cooperation between the agriculture industry and unions, including on submissions to government on skills development and migration, and Commonwealth initiatives to support workforce growth and skills.

Next meeting

Ministers agreed that their next meeting will be held in Perth on Thursday 13 July 2023. This will be the first face-to-face meeting since the pre-pandemic meeting in early 2020.

Ministerial attendees:

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Rebecca Vassarotti, MLA, Minister for the Environment
- New South Wales: the Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: the Hon Paul Kirby MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries
- Queensland: the Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agriculture and Fisheries
- South Australia: the Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regions
- Tasmania: the Hon Jo Palmer MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Water
- Victoria: the Hon Gayle Tierney MLC, Minister for Agriculture.
- Western Australia: the Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-ministers-forum-may-2023>